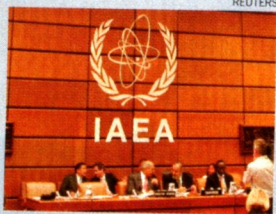


The Marathon Run

India and the US have to clear many more Olympian hurdles

IAEA The safeguards agreement will allow the agency access to reactors that India designates as civilian



The International Atomic Energy Agency is expected to approve the India-specific safeguards, agreement at its Board of Governors meeting on August 1. The safeguards are to ensure that no material in civilian reactors is diverted for military use.

NSG India needs an approval from all the 45 members of the Nuclear Suppliers Group but some members may oppose



The Netherlands: Has concerns over non-proliferation and has to seek approval from its Parliament



Ireland: Believes India is joining the nuclear club through the backdoor. Has raised some concerns.



China: Says the deal would alter balance of power in the region but unlikely to oppose if others support it.



New Zealand: Wants India to sign the CTBT. PM's special envoy Shyam Saran being sent to seek support.



Japan: The only victim of a nuclear attack, it maintains a strong anti-nuke policy, but likely to support the deal



Canada: May support the nuclear deal with a pitch for its nuclear reactors. M.K. Narayanan to enlist support.



Sweden: Has been opposed to the nuclear deal. May play hard ball, Kapil Sibal going to enlist support.



Australia: Rules out supplying uranium to India as the country is not an NPT signatory but may support it.

US Presidential Determination

President Bush will have to make a determination that the 123 bilateral agreement, the safeguards agreement with the IAEA and an NSG waiver are in consonance with US laws. He will then present the deal to the US Congress for its approval.

US Congress

The US Congress has a packed schedule and will only meet in September. But with a bi-partisan support for the deal, the two houses are expected to take the up or down vote for it even before the stipulated time period of 90 days.



Minister of State for External Affairs Anand Sharma and Minister of State in the Prime Minister's Office Prithviraj Chavan to countries such as Spain, Italy, Norway, Finland, Sweden, South Africa, Ghana and Ethiopia. Sharma used the ASEAN regional forum meeting in Singapore to lobby with the foreign ministers of Canada and Australia. "Our focus will be to enlist support of as many countries as possible to ensure that we get a clean exemption from members of the NSG," Sharma said.

Meanwhile, among officials apart from Saran, National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan is headed for Canada, the UK and Russia. Menon will be going to Germany, Austria and Switzerland to lobby support. Other senior MEA officials are being deputed to cover most countries involved in the vote. It is not going to be an easy push through because many governments that initially agreed to back India have changed and the new heads of states have to be spoken too. The tough political battle that Manmohan had fought to push the deal through may actually help in convincing the NSG countries to allow a clean exemption.

After the NSG clearance, which India hopes

Even before the nuclear race is over, Manmohan has emerged as the most famous Sikh the country has known in recent memory.

would come in early September after three rounds of meetings, Bush would make a presidential determination that India has fulfilled all the requirements that the US Congress had stipulated for it to approve the deal. He would then ask the Congress to have what is known as an "up or down" vote on it before the deal can become operationalised. The Congress gets up to 90 days to do so but may decide to vote on it before it goes into recess in the last week of September. Bush administration officials have been in touch with key Congressmen to seek their co-operation. They are encouraged by the fact that the deal has huge bi-partisan support in the current Congress. Manmohan's heroics in the Indian Parliament will play a major role too in helping them push it through.

Manmohan is proving to be the marathon man and even before the race is over, he is well on his way of becoming the most famous Sikh that country has known in recent memory. ■